

NORSE MYTH AND reality

THE VIKING AGE

Medieval Icelandic sagas are filled with strong female characters, which suggests that Scandinavian women during the Viking Age (c.800–1100 CE) could command respect and exercise considerable influence. However, in reality, women had few legal rights and no formal role in public life. They could not be a witness in a legal case, and did not have the right to speak at the *thing* (assembly)—the main political institution—so women’s authority depended to some extent on force of character. Viking society was hierarchical; although an aristocratic woman might have lower status than an aristocratic man, she did have the advantage of being seen as superior to everyone of lower social rank, regardless of their gender.

Divided roles

Gender roles in Viking Age Scandinavia were clearly defined. Men ploughed, hunted, traded, fished, and fought in wars. They also monopolized physically demanding crafts like blacksmithing and carpentry. Women’s lives, on the other hand, were centered on the home and family farm: they baked and brewed; spun thread; wove cloth and made clothes; milked the cows; and churned butter. They also cared for children and the sick.

In wealthy households, women managed the servants and slaves, and looked after the whole family estate if their husbands were away on business or fighting. Women wore the keys to the house and to the family’s strongbox on their belts as a symbol of their domestic authority, and a wife would expect her husband to consult her on decisions affecting the family’s welfare. Females also had a special role in pagan religion as practitioners of *seiðr*, a dangerous magic said to be gifted by the fertility goddess Freyja, which endowed them with the power of prophecy.



▲ Remnants of a bygone age

Brooches—such as this example found in Norway—have been crucial for identifying graves of Viking women. They were not only decorative, but also held layers of clothing in place.

